

Chapter

No Situation Is Permanent — The Gita's Path Through Life's Struggles



Introduction: Why Doesn't the Situation Change?

Every one of us meets some hardship that begins to feel permanent — an illness, a broken relationship, or a shortage of money. In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji asks: when Shri Krishna himself says that pleasure and pain come and go, why do we carry one situation for our whole life? He answers from the fourteenth verse of the second chapter of

the Bhagavad Gita, and then from the journey of the whole Gita.

Three Kinds of Bondage: Illness, Relationships and Poverty

Acharya Ji first sets out the situations in which we stay entangled. The first is illness:

"What the big doctors call an incurable disease — they say 'there is no remedy' — then we get frightened too. And then we sit with that disease for our whole life."

The second is bitterness in relationships:

"Or some relationship of ours goes bad, we keep quarrelling with someone, and then we carry that quarrel on for lifetimes."

And the third is financial hardship:

"Or our financial condition — money, wealth — someone is in poverty, there is too little, there is no job, and they spend their whole life like that. So why doesn't this situation change?"

To answer this question, he takes us to the Gita:

"For that you will have to read a little of the Bhagavad Gita too. Open chapter two, verse number 14."

Shri Krishna's First Teaching

Acharya Ji explains that Shri Krishna's first teaching in the Gita is in this very verse:

mātrā-sparśās tu kaunteya śītoṣṇa-sukha-duḥkha-
dāḥ

āgamāpāyino 'nityās tāṁs titikṣasva bhārata

"O son of Kunti, the contacts of the senses with their
objects give rise to cold and heat, pleasure and pain.

They come and go and are impermanent; endure
them, O Bharata."

— Bhagavad Gita 2.14

He first reminds us that there is a cause behind the situation
we are in:

"Whatever situation you are in, it must have come
partly through prarabdha; there must be some such
karma, some such saṁskaras."

Prarabdha means the fruit of past actions that has come to be
experienced in this life.

Then he opens up the meaning of the verse:

"O son of Kunti, cold and heat — meaning the pair of opposites, the dvandva, that comes through the body — cold and heat, pleasure and pain. Pleasure and pain refer to the state of the mind. Opposites will keep coming."

"This is called adverse and favourable circumstances — unfavourable, favourable condition. In life, ups and downs will keep coming."

The pairs of opposites — cold and heat, pleasure and pain, favourable and adverse — will keep coming in life; this is the nature of life.

Where Pleasure and Pain Are Born

The word **mātrā-sparśa** in the verse — the contact of the senses with their objects — Acharya Ji explains through everyday examples:

"What gives these are the indriyas — indriya means our sense organs, your organs — and their union with sense objects; these arise and perish, and are impermanent."

"That is, if there is the tongue, then some food — whether it is idli-sambar or anything else. Or if there is the ear, then a great deal of music to hear, or some word. Or touch — sound, form, everything is there."

"So when all this comes into contact — relationships come in, the five great elements come in — something is produced from that union; something arises. What? Either pleasure or pain."

The **pañca-mahābhūta** — earth, water, fire, air and space — are the five elements of which the whole material world is made.

If It Is Impermanent, How Can It Be Permanent?

This is where Acharya Ji's main question arises. What arises from such a union — what is it like?

"It is said — it is perishable and impermanent. How does your illness become permanent? My question is, how can a doctor say that cancer is permanent?"

"You have got diabetes, so now it will never go, now you will have to take this for your whole life — whereas Krishna himself says it is impermanent. Nothing is permanent. He said, the only thing that is constant is change. And change must happen."

He applies the same point to poverty:

"How does my poverty become fixed? It is impermanent — it actually should go after some days."

And he clarifies a subtle meaning of the word **perishable**:

"He said perishable, meaning that situation has arisen — it has come into being — and after that it must perish. Not you; the situation must perish."

But with this comes a necessary caution:

"That means poverty, too, should go after some days. It will not go on its own; you will have to do something for it."

Whatever has arisen is certain to end — it is not you who perishes, it is the situation. But you will have to do something for it.

"Endure" — The First Teaching, Not the Last

At the end of the verse Shri Krishna says *tāṁs titikṣasva bhārata* — endure them. Acharya Ji looks at this within the order of the Gita:

"So what was the first teaching given, the very first teaching? That you should endure. But is this the final teaching?"

"In the first chapter it is only Arjuna who speaks, and in the second chapter, up to the tenth verse too, it is only Arjuna who speaks. From the eleventh verse Shri Krishna's words begin, and in the fourteenth verse itself he says this first."

He holds that this is our first difficulty:

"And a person cannot even endure properly — that is the problem."

But endurance is not the destination in itself:

"'Endure this' — he did not say, keep enduring, enduring, enduring and spend your whole life that way. After enduring, you have to go through the third chapter, the fourth chapter, the fifth, sixth, seventh, all the way to the eighteenth chapter — do you have to go or not?"

Endurance is the beginning of the journey, not its end. The Gita takes us from the second chapter to the eighteenth.

After Endurance: The Whole Journey of the Gita

Acharya Ji briefly describes what the Gita teaches after endurance.

Karma Yoga (Chapter Three):

"In the third chapter he speaks about karma yoga — you will have to do some new action. Not only action, but yoga — you will have to join something, he said there."

Yajna (Chapter Four):

"In the fourth chapter he explained how yajna is performed — not only that physical yajna. What does yajna mean? 'Yajna' means, it comes from the word 'yaj'; yaj means to sacrifice, to renounce."

Devotion and Meditation (Chapters Five and Six):

"Then in the fifth chapter he will speak about bhakti. In the sixth chapter, how sadhana is to be done — meaning the state of meditation. That is, karma, bhakti, jnana, dhyana — all four explain some form of yoga."

Knowledge of Brahman (Chapters Seven to Twelve):

"From the seventh chapter up to the twelfth chapter, the process of knowing 'how I myself am that Brahman' is given. There is the Virat Roop, isn't there — all of that is described in the eleventh chapter."

The Process and the Three Gunas (Chapters Thirteen to Eighteen):

"From the thirteenth chapter to the eighteenth — what its process is, how they arise, what the three gunas are — this process is given."

The **three gunas** — sattva, rajas and tamas — are the three qualities of nature that shape our thoughts and actions.

And at the end, Acharya Ji leaves a question before us:

"So such a long process — what do you think, did Krishna tell it to Arjuna?"

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 No hardship is permanent.** Illness, broken relationships and poverty need not be carried for a lifetime; Shri Krishna says they are **impermanent**.
- 2 The pairs of opposites are the nature of life.** Cold and heat, pleasure and pain, favourable and adverse circumstances will keep coming and going.
- 3 Pleasure and pain are born of contact.** Every experience that arises from the contact of the senses with their objects is subject to arising and perishing.
- 4 It is the situation that perishes, not you.** Whatever has arisen must end — but it will not go on its own; you will have to do something for it.
- 5 "Endure" is the first teaching, not the last.** Spending life merely enduring is not the message of the Gita.

6 **After endurance comes the whole journey of the Gita**
— karma yoga, yajna (sacrifice), bhakti, meditation,
knowledge of Brahman and understanding of the three
gunas. This is the way through life's struggles.